CHAPTER 9

Final Stage of a Group

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Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook



CHAPTER LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Describe the dynamics associated with group process and development (CACREP, 2016, Standard B)
2. Discuss the main leader and member tasks of the final stage of a group
3. Identify issues in effectively terminating a group experience
4. Explain the importance of dealing with feelings of separation
5. Suggest guidelines for dealing with good-byes in an effective manner
6. Explain some methods for reviewing the group experience
7. Understand how practice outside of the group is necessary for behavioral change to occur
8. Clarify the kind of feedback that is useful during the final stage of a group
9. Describe how contracts and homework help members consolidate their learning
10. Understand how to deal with setbacks and explain relapse prevention strategies
11. Explore guidelines for applying what is learned in a group to daily life
12. Identify methods for evaluation of a group experience
13. Explore coleader issues at the end of a group
14. Describe methods of follow-up after a group ends

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Your internship is coming to an end, and you will need to close the group you have been leading for 10 months. You have been working with inpatient, single mothers dealing with drug rehabilitation and childhood abuse issues. Many of the women have issues of abandonment and loss in their history. During your final meeting, one of the members is absent and you don't know why. Another member brings up a serious problem that cannot be adequately attended to at this late stage. The group had achieved a high degree of cohesion, and you are surprised by a hostile confrontation between two of the members.

- How will you address these issues with the members during the termination phase?
- Could you have done anything to prevent these occurrences?
- What would you be inclined to do about the member who was not present?
- How would you address the member's absence in the group?
- What issues around loss do you have, and how do you typically handle good-byes in your own life?
- What key clinical issues will members be dealing with at this stage?
- What ethical considerations are pressing?
- How might your theoretical orientation influence how you make sense of these client behaviors and intervene with group members?

LO1

Introduction

The initial phase of a group's development is crucial—participants are getting acquainted, basic trust is being established, norms are being determined that will affect later intensive work, and a unique group identity is taking shape. The final stages of the evolution of a group are equally vital—members have an opportunity to clarify and integrate the meaning of their experiences in the group, consolidate the gains they have made, and decide what newly acquired behaviors and changes they are committed to bringing to their everyday lives.

In this chapter we discuss ways of bringing the group experience to an end and describe how you can help members evaluate their experience in the group. The group leader's theoretical orientation will influence the way termination issues are approached. Important topics we address for the final stage of a group include the following:

- Tasks members need to accomplish in the termination process
- Techniques to help members consolidate learning and deal with unfinished business
- Importance of exploring members' thoughts and feelings about the ending of the group
- How to prepare members for leaving the group and applying their new behaviors in daily life
- How to evaluate the effectiveness of the group and gain feedback from the group members

Endings in a therapeutic group are frequently emotionally charged and complex events. Several tasks need to be accomplished in the final stage of a group's history, but it is difficult to offer one general guideline that covers all kinds of groups. Many variables must be considered in deciding how much time to allow

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for ending. For example, the number of sessions devoted to reviewing and integrating the group experience is dependent on how long the group has been in existence and whether the group is an open or closed group. Whatever the type of group, adequate time should be set aside for integrating and evaluating the experience. There is a danger of attempting to cover too much in one final meeting, which can have the effect of fragmenting the group instead of leading to transferable learning. The most important thing about the group experience is what the members take with them by way of new learning to enhance the quality of their lives.

Endings in a therapeutic group are frequently emotionally charged and complex events.

LO2

Tasks of the Final Stage of a Group: Consolidation of Learning

The final phase in the life of a group is the time for members to consolidate their learning and develop strategies for transferring what they learned in the group to daily life. At this time members need to be able to express what the group experience has meant to them and to state where they intend to go from here. This is a time for members to process their feelings and thoughts about their experience in the group. For many group members, endings are difficult. Members need to face the reality of termination and learn how to say good-bye. If the group has been truly therapeutic, members will be able to extend their learning outside, even though they may experience a sense of sadness and loss.

As a leader, your task is to assist members in learning to put what has occurred in the group into a meaningful perspective. One of the purposes of a group is to implement in-group learning in the daily life of members. The potential for learning permanent lessons is likely to be lost if the leader does not provide a structure that helps members review and integrate what they have learned.

In a *closed* group that has had the same members for all sessions, the task of leaders is to help members review their individual work and the evolving patterns from the first to the final session. In these groups it is particularly valuable for members to give one another feedback on specific changes they have made.

An *open* group has different challenges because members leave the group and new members are incorporated into the group at various times. The termination process is most meaningful when members have ample time to explore their thoughts and feelings both when a member is leaving and when a new member enters the group. Here are some tasks to be accomplished with a person who is terminating membership in an *open* group:

- Educate members to give adequate notice when they decide it is time to terminate. This will ensure that members have time to address any unfinished business with themselves or others in the group.
- Allow time for the person who will be leaving to prepare emotionally for termination.

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- Give an opportunity to others to say good-bye, to share their own reactions, and to give feedback. Remaining group members often have reactions about the loss of a member, and it is essential that they have an opportunity to express their thoughts and feelings.
- Explore cultural influences on members' perceptions and understandings of endings. For cultures that emphasize continuity of relationships, endings may be viewed as an interruption rather than a permanent reality. Other cultures may view an ending as a permanent severing. These different understandings and reactions to endings need to be processed within the group (Mangione, Forti, & Iacuzzi, 2007).
- Help members who are leaving the group identify how they can incorporate what was meaningful in the group into their daily life. Their experiences and lessons learned can help them face future challenges throughout their lifetime.
- Assist the member who is leaving to review what has been learned in the group and, specifically, what to do with this learning. Review and reinforce changes made by each of the members of the group.
- Make referrals, when appropriate.

Sometimes members will terminate without any prior notice. If it is at all possible, group leaders can encourage such members to explore their motivations for terminating and to remain in the group long enough to address possible reasons for termination. How would you deal with a member who stated that she has to leave the group due to unforeseen circumstances? If this member wanted to remain in the group, but would be absent for a considerable time, how would you address this request?

LO3

Termination of the Group Experience

The issues that arise during the termination stage are as varied as the members, however, several themes are common to many groups. Some members will engage in behavior that makes it easier for them to leave the group. They might present themselves as distant, problematic, and argumentative. In some cases, they diminish the work that they themselves or other members have accomplished. Just like members' behaviors throughout the group, their style of leaving reveals a great deal about how they handle pain, unresolved loss, and grief. Many people have experienced negative or unhealthy good-byes in their life, and group leaders can teach members how to process endings and have a sense of closure both in the group and in relationships outside of the group.

Some group counselors believe that termination begins on the first day of group and that leaders should prepare members throughout for the eventual ending of a group. This is a task that the leader in the opening vignette may not have adequately attended to, such as stressing the importance of bringing up unfinished business before the last session to allow time to address these concerns. The key is to raise issues of termination at the right time. The way group leaders talk about the upcoming ending will differ based on a variety of factors:

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whether the group is an open or closed one, the loss or abandonment concerns that members have experienced, the length of time the group has been together, the age of the group members, the psychological functioning of the group, and the level of cohesion within the group. Group members may experience and express closure differently due to their cultural background, and leaders should be aware of these cultural differences in the termination process. These are just a few of the factors to consider when determining *when* and *how* to address termination.

Critical Incident

An Uneventful Termination Session

1. Description of Incident

In the final session of a personal-growth group, the group leader noticed that group members appeared disengaged and were unwilling to interact with one another. The leader was concerned that this termination session was an anticlimactic end to the group. When the group facilitator shared his observations with the group, one group member stated, "I guess we just feel like our work in the group is done, so we don't really know what to talk about." Another member commented that he was angry with several group members but didn't want to talk about it because the group was ending. A third member said, "I don't like good-byes. Can't we just keep meeting as a group?"

2. Process Questions for Group Leaders

1. Why might group members seem silent during a termination session?
2. What feelings might group members be having at a closing session?
3. How could you prepare group members for the termination session?
4. What types of closing activities might you present to the members?
5. At what stage would you talk about termination issues with group members?
6. How might a group member's style of exiting the group be indicative of his or her past or present relationships outside of the group?
7. How would you describe what an effective good-bye looks like?
8. How do you typically handle endings or good-byes in your own life?

3. Clinical Reflections

The group leader interpreted the members' behaviors as being "low energy" and "uninvolved." In fact, members were experiencing a wide array of feelings and thoughts about the ending of the group. The sense of flatness may have been a way for some members to minimize the importance of the group. Some members may have stirred up conflict or disengaged emotionally to avoid painful good-byes. Sometimes it is easier for members to leave one another if they are angry or tell themselves they don't really care. Acknowledging positive feelings and leaving others on good terms is a foreign experience for many people.

Leaders need to prepare members early for termination. Deciding when to talk about termination depends on many factors. For some members, two or three sessions before the end of group will be enough, and for others it may need to be talked about at each stage of the group. How the group members end with one another often is as important as what they learned throughout the group. We find that many group members have regrets about good-byes they have had in their lives and are not sure how to end in effective ways. Termination can be a bittersweet stage of a group, providing

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members with new ways of experiencing loss, having closure, and acknowledging the impact that they have had on one another. Leaders' feelings about dealing with endings in their own lives can have a significant impact on how they address termination issues in their groups.

4. Possible Interventions

1. Instead of being too quick to interpret the silence as members checking out, share what you are noticing with the group: "I notice that there is a great deal of silence in the group today."
2. Leaders can use incomplete sentences as a way of introducing the unspoken reactions in the room. Facilitate a "go-around" and ask members to finish one of these incomplete sentences: "As this group is coming to an end, I am aware of. . ." "One regret I have about this being our last session is. . ." "I don't like good-byes because. . ." "I want others to remember me as. . ." "Something I hope I will remember about this group experience is. . ." The leader can use this activity to help bring to the surface unfinished business that is present but not being verbalized by the group.
3. Create a "group metaphor," in which the facilitator prompts, "If this group were a movie, what would be the plot? The title? The characters' roles?"
4. Conduct a group art activity in which members co-create a piece of art, allowing each member to take a piece of the creation home.
5. Several sessions before the termination session, ask members how they would like to bring their group to closure. This intervention will likely raise numerous reactions to the reality that they will need to say good-bye, which prevents the good-bye from happening without any forethought or intention.
6. Provide group members with a memento to take home, such as a quote that resonates for each member or a small totem to represent the individual, so members can remember the group and what they learned.

Group Proposals Illustrate Ending of a Group

In Chapters 10 and 11 various group proposals illustrate how to prepare members for the ending of a group and how to structure the final session. In a group for children who have been abused in Chapter 10, the last session is devoted to a celebration of the group experience. The main purpose is to provide a context for members to reflect on what they have learned about themselves and others. Because Teresa Christensen gives the children in her group an opportunity to participate in structuring the closing sessions, the structure for this termination often varies. However, she requests that the members share this kind of information: (a) what they have learned about their individual strengths and talents, (b) how they plan to continue making positive choices and building healthy relationships outside of group, and (c) their individual plans about how to take care of themselves.

In Chapter 11 participants in an older adult bereavement group are provided with a further opportunity to learn how to deal with loss in a healthy manner as this group ends. Alan Forrest encourages members in his bereavement group to address any unfinished business toward the deceased or toward other group members or the facilitators. Group participants also are encouraged to provide each other with feedback on their experience in the group and to say good-bye. The members can talk about what it will be like for them to no longer have this group, to explore what the group experience has meant to them, and to examine their plans for continued support. Rituals, such as having each participant light a

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candle that represents the deceased and share their reactions about the deceased, helps members consolidate what they have learned and provides further emotional healing. In this final shared experience, light is used as a metaphor for insight and illumination, and the candle provides each participant with something concrete to take home. As you look at the other group proposals in Chapters 10 and 11, you will notice that all of the group counselors take the matter of termination seriously and prepare members to deal with their thoughts and feelings about the ending of their group.

Dealing With Feelings of Separation

LO4

In discussing the initial phase of a group, we commented on the importance of encouraging members to express their fears and expectations so that trust would not be inhibited. As members approach the ending of a group or are leaving an ongoing group, it is equally essential that they be encouraged to express their reactions. They may have fears or concerns about separating. For some, leaving the group may be as anxiety producing as entering it. Certain members are likely to be convinced that the trust they now feel in the group will not be replicated outside. A central task of the leader at this time is to remind members that the cohesion they now have is the result of active steps they took. Members need to be reminded that close relationships do not happen by accident; rather, they are the product of considerable struggle and commitment to work through interpersonal conflicts.

Even if the participants realize that they can create meaningful relationships and build a support system outside the group, they still may experience a sense of loss and sadness over the ending of this particular community. Termination often evokes emotional reactions pertaining to death and mortality, separation and abandonment, and hopes for a new beginning (Rutan et al., 2014). To facilitate members' expressions of their feelings over separation, it is important for leaders to examine their own experiences or difficulties with saying good-bye. Psychoanalytically oriented group practitioners focus on identifying and managing their countertransference, which could interfere with their ability to assist members in exploring their reactions about the termination of the group. Mangione and colleagues (2007) stress that group leaders must be aware of their personal limitations pertaining to endings or loss if they expect to act ethically and effectively in assisting members in dealing with termination. Sixty-two percent of the group therapists who participated in their survey indicated they had experienced difficulties in endings in a group because of events in their personal lives.

Although leaders can take partial credit for group outcomes, they need to assist members in identifying what they did to create a successful group. In our experience, when members want to give us more credit than we think we deserve, we may reply with: "The group was successful because all of us worked hard. If you can remember what you specifically did in here that resulted in desired changes, then you are more likely to be able to create a context for similar changes in your everyday life once this group ends."

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Learning in Action

LO5

Good-Bye Letter

As you reflect on your time in a group that is coming to a close, write a good-bye letter to the experience. You may want to include the answers to some of these questions in your letter and reflection:

- What has your experience in this group been like for you?
- Describe your journey from the beginning to now?
- How did you enter the group?
- How are you leaving the group?
- What did you learn about yourself that you want to remember?
- What did you learn about others that will help you in your relationships?
- What are you taking from other members that you want them to know about?
- Who would you like to thank in the group and for what?
- As you look back on how you participated in the group, is there anything you wish you had done differently?
- In general, how do you handle good-byes?
- What feelings and thoughts are coming up for you as your time in this group is coming to a close?
- Is there a part of you that you want to say good-bye to or leave in the group?
- Do you have any hopes or wishes for others in the group that you would like to share?
- How does your cultural background influence the way you say good-bye?

We encourage you to share the letter you have written with your group members. Make a note to yourself to reread the letter 6 months from now as a reminder of what you worked toward and want to continue learning.

NOTE: This activity can be completed as a member of a class, as a graduating cohort, or as a group member. You also may want to use this exercise at the closing of a group that you are leading.

Comparing Early and Later Perceptions in the Group

In many of the groups we have led, we typically ask members at the first session to spend a few minutes looking around the room quietly. We say: "As you are looking at different people, be aware of your reactions. Are you already drawn to certain people more than others? Are there some in here whom you already feel intimidated by? Are you catching yourself making judgments about people?" After a few minutes of this silent scanning of the room, we ask members to refrain from sharing anything that they have just thought or felt. Generally, we let the members know that we will ask them to repeat this exercise at the final group session. When this time arrives, we tell them: "Check out the room again, being aware of each person here. Do you remember the reactions you had at that first meeting? How have your reactions changed, if at all? How does it feel to be in here now compared with what it was like for you when the group began?" A main task for members during the final session is to put into words what has transpired from the first to the final session and what they have learned about others and themselves. If the group appears different at this final meeting, we ask

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members to reflect on what they did, both individually and as a group, to bring about these changes.

Dealing With Unfinished Business

During the final phase of a group, allow time for expressing and working through any unfinished business relating to transactions between members or to the group process and goals. Leaders cannot prevent unresolved conflicts from surfacing at the time of termination, and there are many possible reasons for such an outburst. A member may be trying to lessen the pain of leaving by "devaluing" others, or the member may have a pattern of leaving relationships in anger. A member may have been sitting on unresolved feelings toward another member for some time. Despite how much we prepare members not to wait until the last session of a group to address lingering reactions, at times these issues come up at the end. Although there may be little time to "resolve" the conflict or unfinished business at the last session, it is still useful to discuss the relevance and impact of the member's choice to withhold reactions until the end of a group. The member could learn from this experience and assess whether or not it is worth it to express his or her thoughts and feelings in similar situations in the future.

It is not realistic to assume that all of the issues that were explored will have been worked through. As mentioned earlier, if members are given this reminder a few sessions before the final meeting, they can be motivated to use the remaining time to complete their own agenda. We often ask this question: "If this were the last session of this group, how would you feel about what you have done, and what would you wish you had done differently?" In addition, the group may point out many areas on which people could productively focus once they leave the group.

Personal Gestures in Expressing the Meaning of a Group Experience

During closing sessions it is not uncommon for members to want to offer gifts or tokens of appreciation to the leaders and perhaps even to one another. Your counseling theory and personal style will likely influence how you view this practice. In our experience it can be a meaningful part of the work that was accomplished as well as lead to a fruitful discussion about being open to both giving and receiving gifts. Whatever your policy on gift giving may be, it can be beneficial to explore the members' intentions within the group. For example, is it a sign of appreciation, or is it out of a desire to have a personal relationship with you once counseling has ended? Is it common in the member's culture to give gifts to mentors or teachers? Exploring the member's intentions in a curious and interested manner can lead to a rich discussion.

Another common occurrence during termination is that clients may ask to give you a hug, or you may be moved to want to hug them. In general it is safest to wait for a client to ask for a hug rather than initiating one yourself. It is useful to think about how you would respond to this ahead of time. For some counselors the idea of touching a client feels off limits, and for others it is a natural expression of the connections that can be made throughout counseling. There is not one way to handle this that fits all situations.

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Reviewing the Group Experience

LO6

At the final stage of a group, we review *what* members have learned throughout the sessions and *how* they learned these lessons. For example, Adam learned that denying his anger had contributed to his feelings of depression and to many psychosomatic ailments. In the sessions he practiced expressing his anger more constructively instead of smiling and denying those feelings, and as a result he acquired important skills. It is helpful for Adam to recall what he actually did to get others to listen to him, for he could easily forget these hard-learned lessons.

Part of our practice for ending groups involves setting aside time for all the participants to discuss matters such as what they have learned in the group, turning points for them, what was helpful and what was difficult about the group, ways that the sessions could have had a greater impact, and the entire history of the group as seen in some perspective. To make this evaluation meaningful, we encourage participants to be concrete. When members make global statements such as "This group has been fantastic, and I grew a lot from it" or "I don't think I'll ever forget all the things I learned in here," we assist them in being more specific. We might ask some of these questions:

- In what ways has the group been meaningful to you?
- When you say that you have grown a lot, what are some of the specific changes you have made?
- What are a few of the things you've learned that you'd most want to remember?

By asking members to pinpoint what they learned about themselves in the group, they are in a better position to determine what they are willing to do with this increased knowledge. We frequently emphasize to members the importance of putting what they have learned into specific language and stating the ways in which they have translated their insights into action.

Learning in Action

Reviewing the Class and Group Experience

Form small groups and discuss what you have learned about yourself up to this point that you think would either contribute to or detract from your effectiveness as a group leader. Explore the following questions:

- How willing have you been to take risks in this class?
- What have you learned about how groups best function (or what gets in the way of an effective group) through your experience in your class and your group experience?
- To what degree did you accomplish your personal goals in your group?
- How did your group deal with the tasks of termination?
- What were significant turning points in your group?
- As a group, how would you evaluate the level of interaction and the cohesion attained?

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Practice for Behavioral Change

LO7

In groups that meet weekly there are many opportunities for practicing new behaviors during each group session. It is good to encourage members to think of how they can continue such work between sessions. Members can carry out homework assignments and give a report in the next session on how well they succeeded with trying new ways of behaving in various situations. In this way the transfer of learning is maximized. Members practice new behaviors in the group sessions as well as putting into practice these more effective coping skills when dealing with emerging concerns.

During the final stage of a group, we draw from many concepts and techniques that are a part of cognitive behavioral approaches in solidifying members' learning. We reemphasize the value of practice (both in group situations and in outside life) as a way of solidifying and consolidating their learning. We rely heavily on role-playing situations and behavioral rehearsals for anticipated interactions, teaching members specific skills that will help them make their desired behavioral changes. We encourage members to continue to take action and to try out new behavioral patterns with selected others outside the group.

We ask members to look at themselves and how they want to continue changing rather than considering how they can change others. If Damien would like his wife to show more interest in the family and be more accepting of his changes, we encourage him to tell his wife about *his* changes and about himself. We caution him about the temptation of demanding that his wife be different. In rehearsals and role-playing situations, we typically ask members to state briefly the essence of what they want to say to the significant people in their lives so that they do not lose the message they most want to convey.

Carrying Learning Further

One of the tasks of the final phase of a group is to develop a specific plan of action for ways to continue applying changes to situations outside of the group. Assisting members in carrying their learning into action is a key function of leaders. It is our practice to routinely discuss with participants various ways in which they can use what they have learned in the group in other situations. For many members a group is merely the beginning of personal change. Some members use the group to do their work, but for others the group is a place of "preparing to change." Sometimes group members spend their time resisting growth or only contemplating change. Then, when the time seems to have run out, they may find motivation for beginning the process of doing things differently in their lives. It is critical to assist these members in defining the steps they will take to translate their new awareness into action. It's never too late to change, and group members can use both their insights gained during the group and their ambivalence to learn new ways of being in their lives.

Assisting members in carrying their learning into action is a key function of leaders.

If a group has been successful, members now have some new directions to follow in dealing with problems as they arise. Furthermore, members acquire some needed tools and resources for continuing the process of personal growth. For this

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reason, discussing available programs and making referrals is especially timely as a group is ending.

One strategy for assisting members in conceptualizing some long-term directions is asking them to project themselves into the future either by writing a letter to themselves or expressing their thoughts in the group. The leader can ask members to think of the changes they would most like to have made by the end of 6 months or 1 year from now. Members can then imagine that the entire group is meeting at one of these designated times and say what they'd most want to tell each other at that time. They can also describe what they will have to do to accomplish these long-term goals.

The technique of **future projection**, often used in psychodrama, is designed to help group members express and clarify concerns they have about their future. Rather than merely talking about what they would like in their lives at some future time, members are invited to create this future time in the here and now. For example, they might role-play with another group member a conversation they hope to have with a loved one. By enacting this future time and place with selected people and by bringing this event into the present, they are able get a new perspective on how best to get what they want. More information on the rationale for using the future projection technique is included in Chapter 4.

Giving and Receiving Feedback

LO8

Feedback from others in the group is especially helpful to members who identify and discuss changes they expect to make in their everyday lives. This preparation for dealing with others outside the group is essential if members are to maximize the effects of what they have learned. Members benefit by practicing new interpersonal skills, by getting feedback, by discussing this feedback, and by modifying certain behaviors so that they are more likely to bring about desired changes once they leave the group.

Throughout the history of a group the members have been giving and receiving feedback, which has helped them assess the impact they are having on others. During the closing sessions, however, we like to emphasize a more focused type of feedback for each person. We generally begin by asking members for a brief report on how they have perceived themselves in the group, how the group has affected them, what conflicts have become clearer, and what (if any) decisions they have contemplated. Then the rest of the members give feedback concerning how they have perceived and been affected by that person.

A potential problem as a group is ending is that members have a tendency to give global feedback, which will not be remembered nor be very helpful. We caution against expressing global sentiments such as "I really like you." "I feel close to you." "You are a super person." or "I will always remember you." Being influenced by the cognitive behavioral approaches, we provide guidelines on how to give meaningful feedback, suggesting that members begin with one of these ideas:

- My hope for you is . . .
- If I could give you one thing, it would be . . .
- Some of the things I've learned from you are . . .

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Feedback at this point has a focus on integration and synthesis of learning. As the group nears termination, constructive feedback is stated in such a manner that the individual is given an opportunity for closure. This is not a time to "hit and run." We do not want people to leave one another with negative or critical feedback, and we ask members to refrain from saying to others what they have never said in prior sessions. This is not the time for members to unload stored-up negative reactions, for the member being confronted does not have a real opportunity to work through this feedback. During this feedback session, we emphasize that participants can make some specific contracts to explore further areas after the group ends. In our practice, we have found that some type of group follow-up session at a later date is useful. This can give the members added incentive to think about ways to keep their new decisions operative.

Journal Prompts

The following questions are meant to serve as prompts for members during the final stage of a group. If you are running groups, you might find these to be useful for your group members to discuss in group or to journal about between sessions. Consider your responses to these questions as either a real or imagined group member.

1. How are you feeling about the ending of the group and the reality of separation between you and group members? What are you doing to cope with these feelings in the group? (Are you pulling back, picking fights, disengaging, expressing grief?)
2. In what ways are you sharing your reactions toward ending with other group members?
3. How are you planning to translate what you have been learning in the group into other areas of your life?
4. What issues of loss or abandonment are being triggered for you, if any?
5. How would you like to say good-bye to the group members and leaders and to your group experience?

Use of a Contract and Homework

LO9

A useful way to assist members in continuing the new beginnings established during the group is to devote time during one of the final sessions to writing contracts. These contracts outline steps the members agree to take to increase their chances of successfully meeting their goals when the group ends. It is important that members develop their own homework and that the plan is not so ambitious that they are setting themselves up for failure. Many of the cognitive behavioral approaches draw heavily from homework interventions during the final stage of a group. For example, reality therapists spend considerable time teaching members specific ways to create successful action plans. If your theoretical orientation is experiential and relationship oriented, your members also may benefit from the planning procedures that are central in a reality therapy group.

If the participants choose to, they can read their contracts aloud so others can give specific helpful feedback. It is also of value to ask members to select at least

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one person in the group to whom they can report on their progress toward their goals, especially now when they are about to lose the support of their weekly group. This arrangement is useful not only for encouraging accountability but also for teaching people the value of establishing a support system as a way to help them bring about desired changes. Here are a few illustrations of contracts members have made during final group sessions:

- Amanda has worked on speaking up more frequently in her classes. She contracts to continue her verbal participation in class and to call at least two of her friends at the end of the semester to let them know about her progress.
- Roland has explored his tendency to isolate himself from people and has made some gains in reaching out to others, both in and out of group. He says that he feels better about himself, and he contracts with several people outside of the group to call, email, or text them once a month.
- Jason became aware of his bias against people who think and act differently from him. In his group he has challenged himself to approach members that he might typically shy away from because of such differences, which resulted in favorable outcomes. Jason wants to continue this new behavior when he leaves the group. With the permission of members, he agrees to email, text, or phone several people whom he initially backed away from to inform them of his progress.

We have recommended using homework during all the stages of a group. As a group is approaching its ending phase, however, homework of a different nature must be crafted. Homework can be included in the contracts members formulate, and measures can be discussed that will help members when the assignments they have given themselves do not materialize as they had expected.

Dealing With Setbacks

LO10

Even with hard work and commitment, members will not always get what they expected from their encounters. During the final stages of a group, it is helpful to reinforce members so that they can cope with realistic setbacks and avoid getting discouraged and giving up. Assisting members in creating a support system is a good way to help them deal with setbacks and keep focused on what they need to do to accomplish their goals. It is important for them to realize that even a small change is the first step in a new direction.

Relapse prevention is a basic part of many cognitive behavioral groups. Whatever your theoretical orientation may be, it is important to have a discussion about relapses and how to cope with unexpected outcomes. The chances of disappointing outcomes are lessened if members have given themselves homework that is manageable. Homework needs to be tailored to each member's contract, and members need to be careful about overambitious plans. If there is a follow-up meeting after the group terminates, this is an excellent time to reevaluate contracts and evaluate the degree to which members' homework is effective. (We consider follow-up meetings later in this chapter.) We stress to members how important it is that they attend the follow-up meeting, especially if they have not done all that they had agreed to do after the termination of the group. The follow-up session is another opportunity to evaluate each member's plan for future action.

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Guidelines for Applying Group Learning to Life

LO11

Certain behaviors and attitudes increase the chances that meaningful self-exploration will occur in a group. At this time we suggest that you refer to the section in Chapter 6 on "Helping Members Get the Most From a Group Experience." As members enter a group during the early phase, we teach them how to actively involve themselves. This teaching continues throughout the life of the group. At the final phase we reinforce some teaching points to help members consolidate what they have learned and to apply their learning to daily life. Toward the end of a group, the participants are likely to be receptive to considering how they can implement what they have learned.

Realize That the Group Is a Means to an End We do not consider a group experience an end in itself. Although feeling close to others may be pleasant, the purpose of a group is to enable participants to make decisions about how they will change their lives, including being able to be close to the important people in their lives. Groups that are therapeutic encourage people to look at themselves, to decide whether they like what they see, and if they so desire, to make plans for change.

As a group approaches termination, your task is to help members reflect on *what* they have learned, *how* they have learned it, and *what* they intend to do with their insights. Members are now in a position to decide what they are willing to do about what they have learned.

Change May Be Slow and Subtle People sometimes expect change to come about automatically, and once they do make changes, they may expect them to be permanent. This expectation can lead to discouragement when temporary setbacks occur. Ideally, members will bring these setbacks back to their group. This realization that the process of change can be slow makes useful material for exploration in a group.

One Group Alone May Not Permanently Change Your Life Those who seek a therapeutic group sometimes hold unrealistic expectations of rapid and dramatic change. Members need to be reminded that a single therapeutic experience, as potent as it may be in itself as a catalyst for significant change, is rarely sufficient to sustain these decisions. People spend many years creating a unique personality with its masks and defenses. It takes time to establish constructive alternatives. People do not easily relinquish familiar defenses, for even though the defenses may entail some pain, they do work. In some ways, the change process is just that—a process, not a final state. Once people make decisions regarding how they want to change and develop a realistic action plan for daily life, implementation of that plan requires ongoing attention and reflection.

What Will You Do With What You Have Learned? At its best, a group will provide moments of truth during which clients can see who they are and how they present themselves to others. It is up to the members to do something with the glimpses of truth they gain. Members may exercise caution in translating what they have learned in a group to their everyday lives. Many people seek therapy

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It is up to the members to do something with the glimpses of truth they gain.

because they have lost the ability to live life meaningfully and have become dependent on others to direct their lives and take responsibility for their decisions. They expect the group to decide for them, or they are sensitively attuned to being what the group expects them to be. If groups are truly useful, members will have gained greater awareness and are likely to make decisions about how they want to be different in everyday life.

Reminding Members About Confidentiality

At the final session we again comment on the importance of keeping confidentiality, even after the group has ended. We caution that confidences are often divulged unintentionally by members enthusiastically wanting to share with others the details of their group experience. We provide examples of how they can talk about the group without breaking confidences. A suggestion we offer is that members can tell others *what* they learned but should be careful about describing the details of *how* they learned something. It is when members discuss the "how" of their experience that they are inclined to inappropriately refer to other members. Also, we encourage participants to talk about themselves and not about the problems of other participants.

LO12

Evaluation of the Group Experience

Evaluation is a basic aspect of any group experience, and it can benefit both members and the leader. Evaluation is an ongoing process throughout the life of a group—or at least at important turning points in the group—that tracks the progress of individual members and the group as a whole. Some type of rating scale can be devised to give the leader a good sense of how each member experienced and evaluated the group. Standardized instruments can also tap individual changes in attitudes and values. Such practical evaluation instruments can help members make a personal assessment of the group and can help the leader know what interventions were more, or less, helpful. A willingness to build evaluation into the structure of the group is bound to result in leaders improving the design of future groups.

After a group ends, we have at times sent a questionnaire to the members. It is quite possible for members to have different perceptions about the group once they have had some distance from it. Asking members to address some of our questions in writing encourages them to again reflect and one more time put into words the meaning of their experience in the group. By writing about their perceptions of the group experience, they are able to evaluate again how effective the group has been for them. Here is a sample questionnaire:

1. What general effect has your group experience had on your life?
2. What were some specific things you became aware of about your lifestyle, attitudes, and relationships with others? What are some changes you have made in your life that you can attribute at least partially to your group experience?

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3. What problems did you encounter on leaving the group and following up on your decisions to change?
4. What effects do you think your participation in the group had on the significant people in your life?
5. Have there been any crises in your life since the termination of the group? How did you handle them?
6. How might your life be different now if you had not experienced the group?
7. Do you have anything to add about yourself and your experience either during or since the group ended?

We use the following measures to evaluate the effectiveness of our groups:

- We conduct individual follow-up interviews with members or keep in contact with members; letters and telephone conversations have been substituted when person-to-person interviews were not feasible.
- We hold one or more postgroup meetings, which is described in a later section.
- We ask members to complete brief questionnaires, such as the one included here, to assess what they found most and least valuable in their group experience.
- We strongly suggest (depending on the type of group) that members keep process notes in a journal. On the basis of their journal notes, which are private, members write several reaction papers describing their subjective experience in the group as well as what they are doing outside the group. These reaction papers are given to us both during the life of the group and after the group has terminated.

Members have continued to report to us that they found the writing they did both during and after the group extremely valuable to them in maintaining their commitment to change. Through the process of writing in a journal, members are able to focus on relevant trends and the key things they are discovering about themselves. They have a chance to privately clarify what they are experiencing and to rehearse what they want to say to significant people. Through their writing, members can recall turning points in the group, evaluate the impact of the group, and put the group experience into a meaningful perspective.

LO13

Coleader Issues as the Group Ends

It is helpful if coleaders are in agreement with each other about not bringing up new material that cannot be dealt with adequately before the end of the group. Members sometimes save up topics until the very end, almost hoping that there will be no time to explore them. It could be tempting to one of the coleaders to initiate new work with such a member, whereas the other coleader may be ready to bring the group to an end.

Here are some specific topics that you can discuss with your coleader during the final stage to ensure that you are working together:

- Are either of you concerned about any member? Are there any things you might want to say to certain members?
- Do you or your coleader have perceptions and reactions about the group that would be useful to share with the members before the final session?

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- Are both of you able to deal with your own feelings of separation and ending? If not, you may collude with the members by avoiding talking about feelings pertaining to the termination of the group.
- Have both of you given thought to how you can best help members review what they have learned from the group and translate this learning to everyday situations?
- Do you have some plan to help members evaluate the group experience before the end of the group or at a follow-up session?

Once the group ends, we encourage coleaders to meet to discuss their experience in leading with each other and to put the entire history of the group in perspective. This practice is consistent with the ASGW (2008) "Best Practice Guidelines," which encourage leaders to process the workings of the group with themselves, group members, supervisors, or other colleagues. Here are some ideas that you might want to process with your coleader as a way to integrate your experiences and learning:

- Discuss the balance of responsibility between the coleaders. Did one coleader assume primary responsibility for directing while the other followed?
- Did a coleader overfunction or underfunction in any area?
- How did your styles of leadership blend, and what effect did this have on the group?
- Did you agree on basic matters such as evaluation of the group's direction and what was needed to keep the group progressing?
- Talk about what you liked and what was challenging about leading with each other. You can benefit by a frank discussion of what each of you learned from the other personally and professionally, including weaknesses and strengths, skills, and styles of leading.
- Evaluate each other in addition to evaluating yourself. Comparing your self-evaluation as a leader with your coleader's evaluation of you can be of great value. Look for areas needing further work; in this way each of you can grow in your capacity to lead effectively.
- You both can learn much from reviewing the turning points in the group. How did the group begin? How did it end? What happened in the group to account for its success or failure? This type of overall assessment helps in understanding the group process, which can be essential information in leading future groups.

It is a good policy for group leaders to write an assessment of the group as a whole and to also make summary comments about individual members, if appropriate. Keeping good notes, especially about the progress of a group, is particularly helpful in terms of making changes in future groups.

LO14

Follow-Up

Postgroup Sessions

In our practice we typically build follow-up group sessions into the scheduled meetings. Such follow-up is recommended by the ASGW (2008) "Best Practice Guidelines": "Group Workers conduct follow-up contact with group members, as appropriate, to assess outcomes or when requested by a group member(s)" (C.3).

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Because members know that they will come together to evaluate their progress toward their stated goals, they are likely to be motivated to take steps to make changes. Participants can develop contracts at the final sessions that involve action between the termination and the follow-up session. Members often use one another as a support system. If they experience difficulties in following through on their commitments after the group, they can discuss these difficulties. It is a matter not so much of relying on one another for advice as of using the resources of the group for support.

At follow-up sessions, the participants can share difficulties they have encountered since leaving the group, talk about specific steps they have taken to keep themselves open for change, and remember some of the most positive experiences during the group itself. Follow-ups also give members a chance to express and possibly work through any afterthoughts or feelings connected with the group experience. As members gain distance from a group experience, they may identify certain regrets or afterthoughts. A follow-up meeting provides an avenue to express such thoughts and feelings about their group experience after the passage of some time.

The group proposal for a women's support group for survivors of incest described in Chapter 11 provides an example of a group that has follow-up procedures built into the treatment program. The group therapist, Lupe Alle-Corliss, schedules several follow-up meetings (6 to 12 weeks after the end of the group) to help the members make the transition from the weekly sessions to being on their own and relying on their support networks outside of the group. Also in Chapter 11 is a group proposal for a men's group in a community agency. As a way to evaluate the group outcomes, the group leader (Randy Alle-Corliss) schedules a follow-up group meeting called the "reunion group." The reunion group gives members a chance to take another look at what the group meant to them and how they have been applying their learning in their everyday lives. The men also have an opportunity to discuss any problems they have encountered in implementing a new style of behavior.

In our groups, we make sure that group members know about the goals for a follow-up session. It is not geared to doing new work; rather, this session is for finding out what people did with their experience in the group in their daily living. The members are asked to report on whether and how they are using their expanded self-awareness in their relationships in the outside world. The follow-up group session is a means of accountability for both the leader and the members. We ask members at the follow-up session whether they are continuing to reach out for what they want. What changes are they making, if any? Are they taking more risks? If they are trying out new behavior, what results are they getting? These are but a few of the topics we explore at a follow-up group session. For additional topics and questions, refer to the questionnaire presented earlier that we use as a basis for evaluation.

A follow-up session offers us one more opportunity to remind people that they are responsible for what they become and the necessity of putting forth the effort required for significant change. This session provides a timely opportunity to encourage and to discuss once more other avenues for continuing the work they did in a group.

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If you administered any pretests to assess beliefs, values, attitudes, and levels of personal adjustment, the postgroup meeting is an ideal time to administer some of these same instruments for comparison purposes. We support the practice of developing an assessment instrument that can be given before members join a group (or at the initial session), again at one of the last sessions, and finally at some time after termination. If you meet with the members on an individual basis to review how well they have accomplished their personal goals, these assessment devices can be of value in discussing specific changes in attitudes and behaviors.

Of course, follow-up group sessions with the entire group are not always practical or possible, but alternative methods are available. Group leaders can send a brief questionnaire to assess members' perceptions about the group and its impact on their lives. Another option is to contact the members of the group via a secure online live video chat program. It is important to have advanced informed consent about how to contact members to avoid potential invasion of privacy or breach of confidentiality.

Points to Remember

Final Stage of a Group

Final Stage Characteristics

During the final phase of a group these characteristics are typically evident:

- There may be some sadness and anxiety over the reality of separation.
- Members are likely to pull back and participate in less intense ways in anticipation of the ending of the group.
- Members are deciding what courses of action they are likely to take.
- There may be some fears of separation as well as fears about being able to carry over into daily life some of what was experienced in the group.
- Members may express their fears, hopes, and concerns for one another.
- Group sessions may be devoted partly to preparing members to meet significant others in everyday life. Role playing and behavioral rehearsal for relating to others more effectively are common.
- Members will be involved in evaluation of the group experience.
- There may be some talk about follow-up meetings or some plan for accountability so that members will be encouraged to carry out their plans for change.

Member Functions

The major task facing members during the final stage of a group is consolidating their learning and transferring it to the outside environment. This is the time for members to review and put into some cognitive framework the meaning of the group experience. Here are some tasks for members at this time:

- Deal with feelings about separation and termination so members do not distance themselves from the group.
- Prepare to generalize learning to everyday life so members do not get discouraged and discount the value of the group work.

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- Complete any unfinished business, either issues brought into the group or issues that pertain to people in the group.
- Evaluate the impact of the group and remember that change takes time, effort, and practice.
- Make decisions and plans concerning changes members want to make and how they will go about making them.

After their group ends, the members' main functions are applying in-group learning to an action program in their daily lives, evaluating the group, and attending some type of follow-up session (if practical). Here are some key tasks for members:

- Find ways to reinforce themselves without the support of the group.
- Find ways to continue new behaviors through some kind of self-directed program for change without the supportive environment of the group.

Leader Functions

The group leader's central goals in the consolidation phase are to provide a structure that enables participants to clarify the meaning of their experiences in the group and to assist members in generalizing their learning from the group to everyday life. Here are some group leader tasks at this stage:

- Assist members in dealing with any feelings they might have about termination.
- Provide members with an opportunity to express and deal with any unfinished business within the group.
- Reinforce changes members have made and ensure that members have information about resources to enable them to make further progress.
- Assist members in determining how they will apply specific skills in a variety of situations in daily life.
- Help members to summarize changes they made and to see commonalities with other members.
- Work with members to develop specific contracts and homework assignments as practical ways of making changes.
- Assist participants in developing a conceptual framework that will help them understand, integrate, consolidate, and remember what they have learned in the group.
- Provide opportunities for members to give one another constructive feedback.
- Reemphasize the importance of maintaining confidentiality after the group is over.

After the termination of a group, leaders have these tasks:

- Offer private consultations if any member should need this service, at least on a limited basis, to discuss members' reactions to the group experience.
- If applicable, provide for a follow-up group session or follow-up individual interviews to assess the impact of the group.
- Provide specific referral resources for members who want or need further consultation.
- Encourage members to find some avenues of continued support so that the ending of the group can lead to new directions.
- If applicable, meet with the coleader to assess the overall effectiveness of the group.
- Administer some type of end-of-group assessment instrument to evaluate the nature of individual changes and the strengths and weaknesses of the group.
- Document a summary report of the group and file your records in a confidential location.



Exercises

Final Stage of a Group

Here are a few exercises appropriate to the final stage of a group. Again, most of the exercises we suggest are suitable both for a classroom and for a counseling group.

1. **Discounting.** When Sophia left her group, she felt close to many people and decided that it was worth it to risk getting close. She tried this at work, was rebuffed, and began telling herself that what she had experienced in the group was not real. Discounting

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the group experience or allowing old patterns to block establishment of new behaviors are common reactions after a group ends. For this exercise, imagine all the things you might say to yourself to sabotage your plans for change. The idea is to openly acknowledge tendencies you have that will interfere with establishing new behavior.

2. **Group Termination.** Students take turns pretending that they are leaders and that the class is a group about to terminate. Consider how to prepare members for leaving a group.
3. **Termination Interview.** A person in the class volunteers to become a group leader and to conduct an interview with a group member (also a volunteer) as though they had just completed a group experience together. For about 10 minutes the group leader interviews the client regarding the nature of his or her group experience. After the exercise the client reacts to the interview.
4. **Future Projection.** During the last session, members can be asked to imagine that it is 1 year (or 5 years or 10 years) in the future, and the group is meeting for a reunion. What would they most hope to be able to say to the group about their lives, the changes they have made, and the influence the group had on them? What fears might they have concerning this reunion?
5. **Remembering.** It is helpful to simply share memories and turning points during the group's history. Members could be given the task of recalling events and happenings that most stand out for them.
6. **Working on Specific Contracts.** During the final sessions, members might formulate contracts that state specific actions they are willing to take to enhance the changes they have begun. These contracts can be written down and then read to the group. Others can give each member feedback and alternative ways of completing the contract.

Questions for Discussion

Here are a few questions for exploration in a discussion group in class:

1. What are the leader's responsibilities when bringing a group to an end?
2. How might you handle an individual's leaving in an open group? How would you introduce a new member into the group?
3. What personal characteristics of yours could get in the way of helping members in your groups deal with separation and termination issues?
4. What guidelines can you develop to help members think about what they learned in a group and identify ways they can apply these lessons to daily life?
5. What are key characteristics of an effective action plan, and how would you encourage members to formulate a plan?
6. What assessment techniques might you use at both the beginning and the end of a group?
7. How can you build evaluation research into your group design? Do you see any value in combining research and practice in group work?
8. What issues would you think of exploring with your coleader after a group terminates?

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Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook

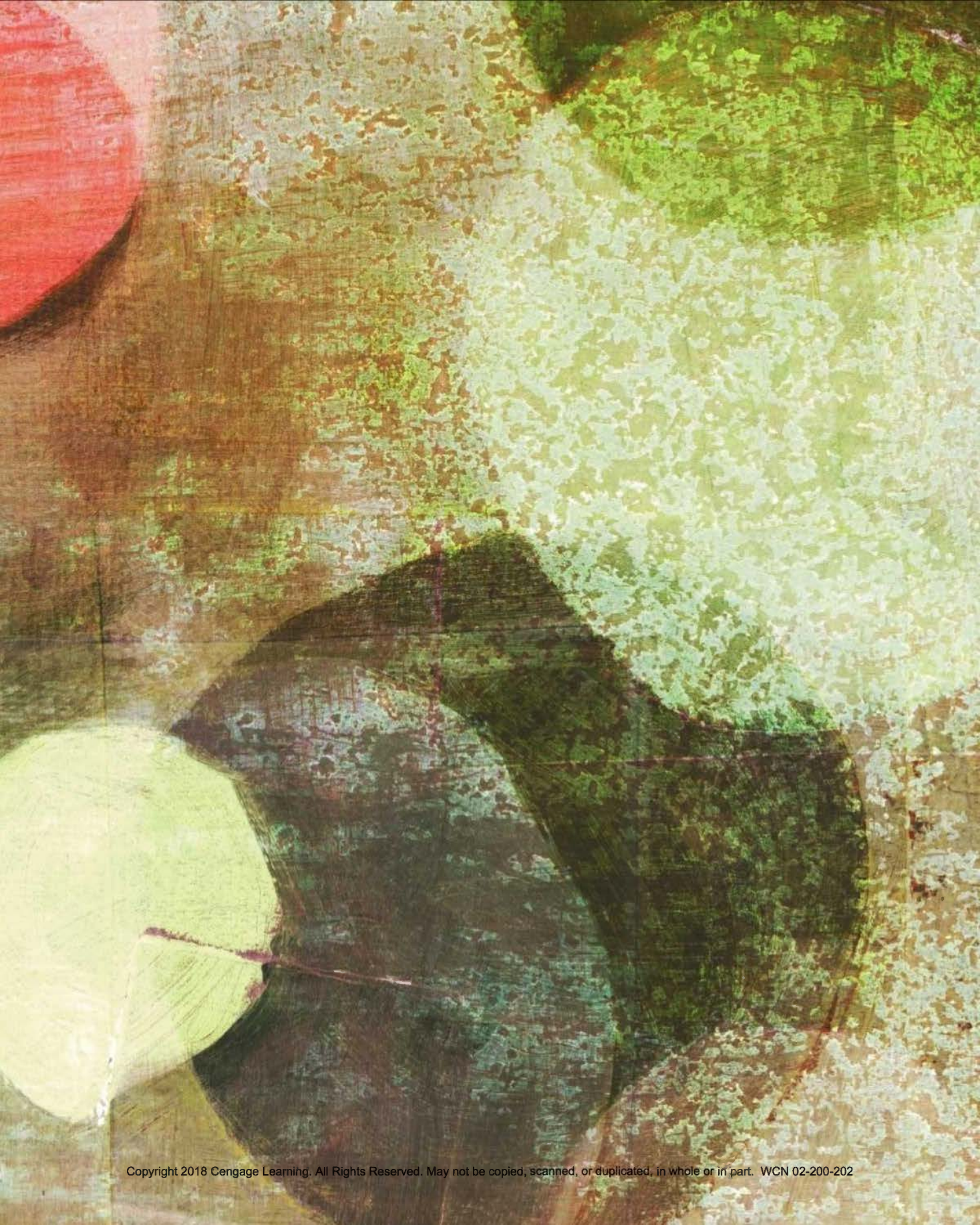
Here are some suggestions for making use of this chapter along with the final stage segment of *Evolution of a Group*.

1. **Tasks of the Final Stage.** Review the tasks that need to be accomplished during the final stage of the group that are presented in this chapter. As you study the ending stage of the DVD group, how do you see these tasks being accomplished?
2. **Termination of the Group Experience.** How are the group members prepared for the termination of a group? How do the members conceptualize their learning? How does the group seem different at this stage than during the early phases of its development?
3. **Using the Workbook.** Refer to Segment 3: Ending Stage in the workbook and complete all the exercises. Reading this section and addressing the questions will help you conceptualize group process by integrating the text with the DVD and the workbook.

MindTap for Counseling

Additional resources can be found on CengageBrain.com and by logging into the MindTap course created by your professor. There you will find a variety of study tools and useful resources that include quizzes, videos, interactive exercises, and more.

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